

UNITED KINGDOM — Business Formation Guide

RKPT TECH LTD | UK Business & Technology Hub *Verified against official government sources — September 2026*

1. Snapshot

Recommended structure	Private Company Limited by Shares (Ltd)
Authority	Companies House
Government incorporation fee	£100 (digital)
Minimum capital	None (no general statutory minimum)
Typical incorporation time	Usually within ~24 hours (not guaranteed)
Full operational setup	1–6+ weeks

2. Recommended Structure

Private Company Limited by Shares (Ltd) is the standard vehicle for most operating businesses. It can have:

- One director and one shareholder — the same person can hold both roles
- No general minimum share capital requirement

A UK company can be registered in **England & Wales**, **Scotland**, or **Northern Ireland**; the registered office must sit in the chosen jurisdiction.

3. Company Formation — Step by Step

1. **Choose jurisdiction** — England & Wales, Scotland, or Northern Ireland
2. **Check company name** — availability, sensitive words, similar names, trademark

conflicts (registration ≠ trademark protection)

3. **Appoint director(s)** — minimum one, must be 16 or older
 4. **Appoint shareholder(s)** — determine share classes and ownership split
 5. **Identify Persons with Significant Control (PSC)** — generally anyone holding more than 25% of shares or voting rights
 6. **Provide a registered office** — a real physical address in the correct jurisdiction; a PO Box alone is not acceptable
 7. **Provide a registered email address** — required, but not publicly displayed
 8. **Complete identity verification** — see Section 8, "Important Information"
 9. **Select SIC code(s)** describing the business activity
 10. **Prepare Memorandum and Articles of Association** — auto-generated for standard filings
 11. **File incorporation with Companies House**
 12. **Corporation Tax setup** — usually triggered automatically on incorporation unless the company is dormant
 13. **Register for VAT** if required or voluntarily appropriate
 14. **Register for PAYE** if employing staff
 15. **Open a business bank account** (separate process, bank's own assessment)
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4. Documents & Information Required

- Company name
- Registered office address (physical, in the correct UK jurisdiction)
- Registered email address
- Director details: full name, date of birth, nationality, residential address (not public), service address
- Shareholder details and shareholdings
- PSC information
- SIC code(s)

- Memorandum and Articles of Association (statement of capital, share details)
 - Identity verification for every director and PSC (GOV.UK One Login or via an Authorised Corporate Service Provider)
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5. Costs (Government fees — separated from other costs)

Official Companies House fees (current schedule):

Transaction	Channel	Fee
Incorporation	Digital	£100
Incorporation (same day)	Digital (software only)	£156
Incorporation	Paper	£124
Confirmation statement (annual)	Digital	£50
Confirmation statement (annual)	Paper	£110
Voluntary strike-off	Digital	£13
Registration of a charge	Digital	£14

Share capital: No general statutory minimum for an ordinary private limited company — this is not a fee.

Typical additional (third-party) costs: registered office/business address service, formation agent, accountant, VAT/PAYE setup, banking support, legal documents, sector-specific licences.

Indicative overall setup budget: approximately **£300–£1,000+**, excluding accounting, VAT, payroll and specialist regulatory costs.

6. Timeframe

Stage	Indicative time
Documentation preparation	1–2 working days
Companies House online incorporation	Usually ~24 hours

Identity verification	10–15 minutes once documents are ready
Business bank account	1–4+ weeks
VAT registration	Variable
Full operational setup	1–6+ weeks

Processing times are indicative only and are not guaranteed by Companies House.

7. Tax & Ongoing Compliance

Item	Rate / Threshold
Corporation Tax — small profits rate	19% (profits under £50,000)
Corporation Tax — main rate	25% (profits over £250,000), marginal relief 19–25% in between
VAT — standard rate	20%
VAT — registration threshold	£90,000 taxable turnover
Employer National Insurance	15% on earnings above £5,000/year
National Living Wage (21+)	£12.71/hour (from April 2026)

Ongoing obligations: annual accounts, confirmation statement (annually, £50), Corporation Tax return (CT600), VAT returns if registered, PAYE if employing staff, PSC register updates, registered office maintenance. The company remains legally responsible for compliance even if an accountant performs the filings.

8. Important Information

- **Identity verification is now mandatory, not optional.** Since 18 November 2025, every new director or PSC must verify their identity with Companies House *before* appointment. Existing directors and PSCs have a transition period ending **18 November 2026** — but in practice, verification is required before the company's *next* confirmation statement is filed, which for most companies falls well before that date. Unverified

individuals cannot file company documents.

- A director does not need to be UK-resident, but the company must maintain a genuine UK registered office.
- Incorporation does **not** automatically grant a visa, residence, or right to work. The **Innovator Founder Visa** is the main UK entrepreneur route — it requires endorsement from an approved body, English at B2 level, and maintenance funds of £1,270 held for 28 days.
- Companies House registration confirms legal existence only — it does not confer trademark protection, banking approval, or authorisation to conduct regulated activities.
- Bank account approval is a separate process; banks conduct independent KYC/compliance checks and approval is never guaranteed.

Disclaimer: Fees, thresholds and requirements change and should be reconfirmed at gov.uk before reliance. This is general information, not legal, tax or immigration advice.

9. Official Sources (checked September 2026)

- Companies House fees — <https://changestoukcompanylaw.campaign.gov.uk/changes-to-companies-house-fees/>
- Companies House identity verification — <https://changestoukcompanylaw.campaign.gov.uk/identity-verification/>
- HM Revenue & Customs — <https://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/hm-revenue-customs>
- UK Visas and Immigration — <https://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/uk-visas-and-immigration>
- GOV.UK — <https://www.gov.uk>